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LARGE & CHARGED

Electric school buses take off in Illinois, with over 200 already on the road and 500 more on the way



Above: Herscher school district bus driver Chris Hadley greets a student as he picks him up in an electric bus in Kankakee County on Dec. 17. **Top:** Herscher students get off an electric bus on Dec. 17. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS**

By Nara Schoenberg
Chicago Tribune

The sun is just beginning to rise over the farm fields of the Herscher school district, 70 miles southwest of Chicago, but the youngest passengers on Bus 24 are already buzzing with excitement.

The second, third and fourth graders climb aboard right on schedule — many decked out in holiday sweaters — and clamor for permission to sing Christmas carols.

When bus driver Chris Hadley reminds them that they’re just days from their winter vacation, they respond with resounding cheers.

But the children reserve some of their greatest enthusiasm for a less obvious crowd-pleaser: What, Hadley asks, do they think of their new electric school bus?

“I love it!”

“I looove it!”

“Brilliant!”

The Herscher district, with 25 full-sized electric school buses on the road, is a clean bus leader in Illinois and part of a growing

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Bills for consent decree pile up

With CPD reform seeing slow progress, city has paid monitor \$19M over 5 years

By Sam Charles
Chicago Tribune

As the scope of the consent decree that governs Chicago’s public safety reforms has grown, so, too, has the city’s legal tab.

From 2019 through 2023 — the first five years of the consent decree — the independent monitoring team responsible for assessing compliance billed the city 35% more than was initially quoted. The nearly \$5 million in extra bills came while the Chicago Police Department continued its slow pace toward compliance, a Tribune data analysis found.

Maggie Hickey, a former federal prosecutor and partner at the law firm ArentFox Schiff, was selected in 2019 to lead the independent monitoring team. Before she was chosen, in a proposal submitted to the city and the Illinois attorney general’s office, the law firm said the first five years of monitoring would cost city taxpayers \$13,990,700.

In that time, ArentFox Schiff actually billed the city \$18,979,213.47, according to a review of submitted invoices.

More than half of that sum — about \$11 million — was to pay for work performed by Hickey and other ArentFox Schiff attorneys, whose rates can exceed \$400 per hour. The other \$8 million was needed to cover other charges and disbursements owed to other subject matter experts contracted by the monitoring team, the documents show.

Billing made public by the monitoring team also show ArentFox Schiff billed the city another \$3,145,700.99 in the first seven months of 2024.

At last check, CPD was within operational compliance with 9% of its consent decree obligations. The Civilian Office of

Turn to Bills, Page 3

Fate of some Cabinet picks still unclear

Controversy over nominees places pressure on the GOP

By Mary Clare Jalonick
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — The fate of President-elect Donald Trump’s Cabinet is still unclear after Republican senators spent much of December carefully dodging questions about Robert F. Kennedy Jr.’s views on vaccines, accusations of sexual misconduct against Pete Hegseth and Tulsi Gabbard’s 2017 meeting with then-President Bashar Assad of Syria.

While some GOP senators have indicated they are all in for Trump’s picks, others have withheld support, for now, especially on some of his more controversial nominees. The dynamic is injecting uncertainty into the process as Republicans prepare to take the Senate majority in January with a four-seat margin and as Trump aggressively challenges them to confirm his Cabinet immediately.

It’s not unusual for senators to wait until after confirmation hearings to publicly announce a decision. But Republicans are under more pressure than usual as Trump and his allies make clear that they will confront senators who don’t fall in line.

“You only have control of the Senate because of Donald Trump,” the president-elect’s son, Donald Trump Jr., warned during a media appearance this month. “Without that, you’d be relegated to insignificance.”

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“I just really want to support my grandkids. I want them to know that somebody — not to say that their parents don’t care, and I’m not implying that — but somebody loved me enough to say, ‘Hey, I got you.’” — Jeannette Byrd, whose two grandchildren were placed in her care through the foster system

A piece to the family puzzle

Relatives of children in DCFS care would have better access to state assistance under bill

By Olivia Olander
Chicago Tribune

At 48, having raised three children now in their 20s, Jeanette Byrd is back in a world of diapers, day care and cartoons.

In the last two years, Byrd’s 3-year-old granddaughter and 1-year-old grandson were placed in her care by the Department of Children and Family Services, and now she’s on the path toward permanent guardianship of the children.

“If I can’t, then who will?” Byrd said of her decision to take care of her grandchildren.

The kids — energetic toddlers who are quick to offer a toy, a hug or one of their tiny Nike sneakers — are two of more than 10,000 young people in DCFS care who live with relatives, according to the American Civil Liberties Union of Illinois.

Byrd had to go through a lengthy process to get certified as a guardian for the kids while also holding down a job as a fire inspector and, more recently, studying for her bachelor’s degree in health care administration online. She went through a back-



Jeannette Byrd cares for one of her two grandchildren placed with her through the foster system at her home in Berkeley on Dec. 16. Legislation that would make it easier for those like Byrd to get licensed as foster parents and receive assistance is expected to be considered in early January by the Illinois House. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

ground check process she said was similar to what she already had to do for her job, and took hours of classes on parenting to be able to receive support from the state. The state licensing procedure allowed her to receive benefits including about \$1,300 a month in financial assistance.

Legislation that would make it easier for relatives like Byrd to get licensed as foster parents and receive assistance is expected to be considered in early January by the state House, having already passed through

the Senate. Gov. JB Pritzker has said he will sign the measure if it gets to his desk.

About 60% of family members caring for children under the auspices of DCFS could gain access to additional financial help through provisions in the bill, according to the Illinois ACLU, which has helped shepherd the bill through the General Assembly. That could bring additional resources to thousands of families statewide.

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